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ABSTRACT
This article draws on Lauren Berlant's work to explore the notion of crisis and the critical nature of relations in Michael Christie's novel *Greenwood*. I use Berlant's approach broadly, transcending their specific temporal framework and reading their ideas alongside other theories in the fields of settler colonialism, affect, and ecology. I argue that settler and extractive colonialisms operate in tandem in the novel, installing a critical continuum that permeates the narrative and is often mediated through affective structures. The characters are entangled with one another in a kind of narrative relay that structures the novel's multitemporal framework, fluctuating between the exceptionality of crisis and its ordinariness. I further claim that underneath this complex structure of interconnections, Christie highlights the power of the relations between human and non-human beings as well as the extraordinary potential of literature to articulate those relationships, echoing Berlant, in terms of intimacy and reciprocity.

Introduction: Narratives of Crisis

In their seminal book *Cruel Optimism*, Lauren Berlant explores contemporary Western neoliberal societies through a notion of systemic crisis that they call "crisis ordinariness." While crises have traditionally been understood as isolated dramatic events that disrupt the regular rhythm of life, Berlant argues that under late capitalism people experience a continuous sense of instability that renders crisis the very fabric of the ordinary. Articulated as a temporal impasse, crisis ordinariness involves a suspension of the present, a "regime" under which "life feels truncated, more like desperate doggy paddling than like a magnificent swim out to the horizon" (117). Rather than being oriented toward some form of progress, contemporary everyday life is experienced as a "slow death," a continuous process of attrition under neoliberalism's systemic pressures (96). It follows that the affects and effects of this process are always distributed unevenly among the population, prioritizing certain groups and individuals over others, and highlighting, in doing so, the differential structure of social vulnerability.

From political theory to literary and cultural studies, from feminist and queer theory to the environmental humanities, contemporary scholarly work across a wide array of fields demonstrates the versatile potential of Berlant's thought to resonate with present-day experiences of life in the West. Following Berlant, scholars problematize the formulation of crisis as a dramatic disjuncture from everyday experience, looking into that experience as itself a site of constant precarity and uncertainty, especially for vulnerable collectives and individuals for whom life "is always already a threat to life itself" (Sanders 1). Fabian Bernhardt and Jan Slaby, for instance, reject the approach to the Covid-19 pandemic as a dramatic turning point, conceptualizing it, instead, as an affective stasis, the sense that "everyday life remained strangely unmoving [. . .] as if not only social life, but time itself had come to

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a halt." Elizabeth DeLoughrey takes Berlant's ideas to the field of decolonial studies, contesting "the use of narratives of disjunction and rupture" to describe environmental crises in the Anthropocene, and claiming the need to attend to "the historical continuity of dispossession and disaster caused by empire" (2). Applying the notion of crisis ordinariness to the current climate emergency, Ajay Singh Chaudhary in his turn argues that "Berlant's proposition that this moment is characterized by 'crisis-shaped subjectivity,' that we are all (differently) *feeling* our way through a long, unraveling present, couldn't be more timely." The ubiquitous and prolonged nature of present global environmental crises, Chaudhary asserts, cannot be cast into "the genre of the dramatic event," but is "more accurately described as of a piece with the seemingly more quotidian struggles and exhaustions of daily life under capitalism."

This article draws on those ideas to explore the notion of crisis and the critical nature of relations in Michael Christie's novel *Greenwood*. The text may be read as part of an expanding constellation of works, including Rebecca Campbell's *Arboreality* (2022), Richard Powers' *The Overstory* or Annie Proulx's *Barkskins* (2016), that collectively signal the increasing visibility and critical significance of arboreal fiction.[1] *Greenwood* moves back and forth between historical and dystopian contexts to tell the highly serendipitous stories of four generations of a Canadian family between 1908 and 2038 through their multifarious points of connection with the lives of trees. I argue that settler and extractive colonialisms operate in tandem in the text, installing a critical continuum that permeates the narrative and is often mediated through affective structures. I propose therefore to use Berlant's approach to crisis in a broad sense, transcending their specific temporal framework and putting their ideas in conversation with other theories in the fields of settler colonialism, affect, and ecology. The large time span of the novel does not seem fortuitous but intended to encompass the main social and economic crises of the 20th and 21st centuries: World Wars I and II, the Great Depression, the Oil Crisis, the Great Recession, and the ultimate crisis, an environmental catastrophe at the planetary level. Each character is shaped through the narration of an acute personal crisis and set against the broader backdrop of the social, ecological, and economic instabilities characteristic of their respective historical moments. Moreover, the characters are subtly entangled with one another, in a kind of narrative relay that not only exposes unexpected, and often unwelcome, connections among them, but also, crucially, structures the novel's multitemporal framework, fluctuating between the exceptionality of crisis and its ordinariness.

Building on Berlant's works, a large body of scholarship concurs that the present experience of unremitting instability constitutes a form of *slow crisis* that saturates the ordinary and permeates every aspect of our daily existence. However, in the final chapter of *Cruel Optimism*, Berlant also writes about hope, putting forward the need "to recast the ordinary" (263) in ways that "break the double-bind of cruel optimism, not reentering the normative public sphere while seeking a way, nonetheless, to maintain its desire for the political" (230). With this goal in mind, Berlant turns to the power of literature and art to show how it is possible to transcend the "undramatic flatness" of the present and reactivate a sense of solidarity, intimacy, and reciprocity within our lives (227). In their obituary for Berlant's legacy, Judith Butler reflects on this important strand of their work as follows:

> As a literature professor, [Berlant] saw how expectations and devastations can be wrought through structures of plot, and found a way to make clear how these phantasmatic investments in our own doing are part of the larger social problem we must solve, constituting the affective labor required of social critique. At the same time, the imaginary domain remained for Berlant a source of promise, a hopeful site of experimentation where intimacies could lead to a new sense of social connection and solidarity. (Butler)

The analysis of *Greenwood* that follows interweaves the various strands. I claim that underneath the novel's complex structure of interconnections, Christie highlights the power of the relations between human and non-human beings as well as the extraordinary potential of literature to articulate those relationships, echoing Berlant, in terms of intimacy and reciprocity. I start by looking into Christie's intricate web of interconnections as it is carefully articulated through plot, setting, and narrative structure. Secondly, I interrogate the critical nature of relations in the novel by focusing on the

narrative ruptures that destabilize the genealogical project at its core and complicate the settler colonial history operating in the background. Thirdly, I examine the novel's representation of the critical precarities that define life in the 21st-century narrative frames, while also paying attention to the ways in which the narration moves forward across a paralyzing sense of suspended time. The final sections draw on Jane Bennett's notion of vibrancy to probe the text's production of a profound narrative connection between human and the nonhuman forces, particularly trees and books. My ultimate goal is to show how Christie's intersecting criticalities shape the story, rendering it intimate and affectively charged, yet also political. In doing so, I demonstrate how *Greenwood* can transform personal and planetary crises into events of extraordinary resonance.

Interconnectedness

While Berlant's notion of crisis ordinariness does not refer to ecology in a strictly environmental or ontological sense, their approach remains crucial for ecological analysis insofar as ecology is understood as a condition of interdependence among all beings and things. Berlant articulates how subjects live within systems they neither fully control nor escape, foregrounding the affective and infrastructural ties that bind individual lives to broader economic, social, and material conditions. When read alongside new materialist thinkers, that focus on the dense web of relations shaping human life under late capitalism converges with and complements ecological theories of nonhuman entanglement. In *Vibrant Matter*, Jane Bennett calls for the need to get inspiration from "matter and its powers" in order to achieve "a greater sense of the extent to which all bodies are kin in the sense of inextricably enmeshed in a dense network of relations." In this "knotted world of vibrant matter," Bennett contends, "to harm one section of the web may very well be to harm oneself" (Bennett 13). Although coming from a different angle, Bennett's emphasis on human/nonhuman interconnections also resonates with Timothy Morton's take on ecology as "a vast, sprawling mesh of interconnection without a definite center or edge." The cultivation of "a radical intimacy" with "other beings and things, sentient and otherwise" (8) is not necessarily comforting, Morton points out, since practicing what they call "the ecological thought" is as much about love, wonder and delight as it is about loss and confusion (2). As in Berlant's articulation, the ecological crisis is thus described as an affective crisis, a condition where subjects live within the threat of systemic collapse. Thinkers in these fields likewise emphasize the power of affective, and therefore agentive and material, forms of interconnection across human and nonhuman domains.

I argue that *Greenwood* is fully invested in the exploration of these paradoxes, probing the notion of criticality in human relationships but also in the multiple connections between the human and the nonhuman. Heeding Christie's own words in an interview that the core message of the book is "the interconnectedness of all living things" (Christie, Interview), reviewers have often foregrounded this crucial issue as well as the centrality of trees as central symbols of this interconnection. While Clare Saxby asserts that "in this story thickly forested with symbolism and rooted in predestination, there is no such thing as a 'meaningless coincidence'" (Saxby 21), Henley highlights the novel's fine weaving of intersections between the different generations of characters as well as between the characters and the natural environment. For her, Christie's novel "explores the grief of intergenerational trauma, and how it can shape not only the lives of individual men and women, but the fate of the planet itself." In this section, I articulate how the novel's intricate network of interconnections is carefully built through a strategic configuration of geographies, temporalities, and genealogies.

Greenwood is mainly set in Canada between the early 20th century and a near future when climate crises have led to the extinction of most trees from the world. The absence of trees dries the soil, "creating killer dust clouds as fine as all-purpose flour that choke the land" (22), and, as. a chain effect of this "Great Withering," "[f]arms fail, the stock markets go apoplectic, employment dwindles, unchecked wildfire and shortage riots become commonplace, and utter despair becomes the only rational response" (22). Connecting the novel's various temporal frames and holding them together physically and symbolically, Greenwood Island, somewhere off the West Coast of Canada near

Vancouver, is mysteriously home to some of the last remaining old-growth forest. This setting provides the central stage for the novel's pivotal events and the platform for its sustained exploration of crisis as a structural condition of history and life itself. Over the course of the narrative, it shifts from a logging site to a restored green haven, and, eventually, to a luxury resort accessible only to the world's wealthiest, who pay preposterous sums to spend a few days among the trees, "to be transformed, renewed, and reconnected" (3). Fittingly, it is also through this island setting that the novel examines the entanglements between colonial extractivism, ecological devastation, and social inequality. Each character, representing different generations of the Greenwood family, is positioned differently in these entanglements and figured through a distinct relation to the trees and to this island where the trees remain mysteriously alive after the ecological catastrophe.

The novel starts and ends in the near future. A dedicated dendrologist, Jake Greenwood holds a precarious job at *Greenwood Arboreal Cathedral*, a luxury green resort owned by the powerful Holtcorp, where she works as a highly scripted forest guide for the rich tourists, referred to as "pilgrims" to comply with official Holtcorp policy (6). The job, as Saxby rightly points out, is "soul-destroying" since Jake's "relationship with the trees is far more reverent than anything marketed by the Cathedral, and all the more so because she was hired not for her qualifications but for the 'meaningless coincidence of her last name'" (21). Yet the predictability of this script is suddenly broken by two unexpected events that trigger the text's core interconnections. First, on one of her regular tours of the island, Jake discovers the unsettling browning of two old-growth firs, which leaves "her heart banging behind her ribs" (10) for fear that "whatever has protected the Cathedral for so long has now shifted, leaving its trees newly vulnerable to pathogens and intruders" (10–11). Secondly, Jake receives the unexpected visit of her ex-boyfriend, Silas, who tells her about the discovery of a possible ancestor's personal journal that might rewrite her connection with Greenwood Island: "'I'm here because this entire island could be yours, Jake. I mean *legally* yours," Silas tells a skeptical Jake (37).

Apparently unrelated, these two events break the narrative continuum of Jake's precarious life on the island haven in the midst of the ecological crisis elsewhere, disturbing the rhythm of her daily routine as a forest guide by unsettling the description of the island as well as her own presumed identity. While the discovery of the diseased trees marks a moment of criticality in the environmental sense, the small perturbation potentially announcing a transition point for the island's miraculous habitat, the introduction of the journal can be read in Berlant's terms as an event that recasts the crisis ordinariness of Jake's life, promising to transcend its *undramatic flatness* (227). Jake's reaction to the thin "paperbook" suggests this much, taking it in her hands "as a fizzy enchantment spreads through her chest," and admiring the paper's "color of roasted almonds," a remnant of "a time when trees were an inexhaustible resource" (40). Trees and stories appear thus interconnected from the start, activating the plot, moving it backward and then forward and introducing a degree of extraordinariness in the otherwise tedious routine. Revealingly, Jake's thoughts at that moment articulate the interdependence of human life, narrative, and arboreal life, implicitly announcing the central relational framework:

> After a lifetime of knowing virtually nothing about her family, it's like this unexpected burst of names and history has knocked her clean out of her body. But of course there are layers of life that came before her own, the way trees are held up by the concentric bands of their former selves, rings built over rings, year by year. (38)

Tracing the origin of the mysterious journal, the narrative then moves backward to 2008 and the story of Jake's father, Liam, a carpenter who lives in a van while fighting his drug addiction, then to 1974 and Liam's mother Willow, an activist carrying out small boycotts against her father Harris's extractive capitalism, and eventually to 1934 and 1908, to tell the core stories of Harris and Everett and the serendipitous origin of the Greenwood family. A large and significant part of the plot happens in the two innermost rings at the core of the narrative tree, whose intricate details are crucial to the interpretation of the novel. Aptly, it is in these two temporal frames where other important characters also make an appearance: Mrs. Fiona Craig, a Scottish colonial settler and the owner of the land where the first Greenwood boys are reluctantly allowed to settle; Euphemia, the author of the mysterious journal and mother of the baby who, surviving her death, is found by Everett, who eventually names

her Willow; Lomax, Mr. Holt's loyal worker sent across the country in search of both the baby and the journal; Temple, a Saskatchewan farmer who hides Everett and the baby in her property; and Liam Feeney, Harris's "describer" and assistant, after he loses his eyesight, as well as his secret lover. The novel then moves gradually forward in time again to end back with Jake in 2038.

Initially, it seems that the narrative emphasis is placed on how critical conditions originally perceived as external to the characters end up affecting their personal lives. For instance, the family patriarch Harris Greenwood loses most of his fortune when he sells his wood to a Japanese company just before the outbreak of World War II; his grandson Liam is forced to live in his van after being evicted from his home in the 2008 housing crisis; then, in 2038, Liam's daughter Jake is a climate refugee who works as an overqualified forest guide on Greenwood Island, now turned into a luxury resort after the Withering produced a lethal dust of planetary dimensions. However, on a closer reading, the reverse is also true, and the characters' personal attachments move the narrative forward from the most intimate to the social, economic, and political arenas, increasing the sense of critical relentlessness across generations.

Moreover, as already suggested, the novel is built upon the construction of an intimate relationship between humans and trees: Harris makes his living by logging them, while his brother Everett taps them for their sap; a generation later, Willow dedicates her life to saving the trees from being logged, while her son Liam becomes a carpenter of discarded wood. Finally, Jake becomes a botanist who specializes in trees in a world where the trees have died. If these contradictory connections propel the story in unexpected and at times unlikely directions, the book holds together by the originality of its structure, which replicates the rings of a tree trunk. Accordingly, rather than advancing in the linear fashion suggested by the traditional image of a family tree, the story grows like the rings of a tree, moving inward from the outer layers toward the core, then extending back outward again. As Kirby Allison Archer asserts, this structure has a clear narrative purpose, "allowing *Greenwood* to unfold in a way that foregrounds the significance of choices, how the past affects the present, and which environmental realities are within and beyond human control" (138). Additionally, Archer continues, the structure "aligns with Christie's metatextual consideration of the use of trees in the production of books; by 2038, paper books are a rare and expensive commodity" (138). I further argue that, as the plot constantly rewrites itself, each narrative layer or tree ring introducing unexpected events and reconfiguring relations, the trees contribute to the shaping of the narrative in ways that recall Bennett's notion of "distributive agency" (31). This form of agency rejects the notion of a single, autonomous (human) subject as the source of action, emphasizing instead the operations of multiple, interacting vital forces. For Bennett, the critical task lies in mapping the assemblage itself and examining the relational patterns that organize its elements (31–32).

In a later section of this article, I examine how, like the survival of the trees themselves, the vital connection between each character and the trees appears at once mystical and precarious. But, as reviewers of the novel also suggest, Christie offers a rich myriad of entry points. *Greenwood* is a complex family saga, part futuristic climate fiction and part historical novel. Praising the expressive power of Christie's language, Henley writes: "Rich with evocative descriptions of West Coast wilderness and anchored by a deep, visceral bond to the trees that sustain us all, *Greenwood* is a literary page-turner that manages to be both nostalgic and modern, personal and political, intimately human and big-picture historical" (Henley). And, certainly, the project is an ambitious one. In the broader context, the story is underpinned by the history of settler colonialism, a distinct form of colonial domination grounded in capitalist logics of privatized property and profit (McDonald and Grafton xxxi; Vowel 16).[2] *Greenwood* situates the history of logging at the core of the white settler colonial project, cutting across temporal frames and geographical locations through the logic of extractivism, while also tracing the social consequences of land occupation in what is now called Canada. Built upon a critique of this history and connecting the dots with the present precarity of life, Christie's narrative alternatively follows the Greenwood characters as they struggle to make sense of family secrets and gaps in knowledge. Furthermore, and adding to this complex web of interconnections, the novel's narrative strategy echoes

a Foucauldian genealogical approach (141–146), whereby identitary expectations and relational patterns are repeatedly disrupted and reconfigured. "Because even after you cut a piece of wood and lay it straight," Liam ponders, "it lives on after you're finished, soaking up moisture, twisting, bowing, and warping into unintended forms. Our lives are no different" (428). In the following section, I explore the critical nature of these shifting relationships.

Critical Relations

I have previously mentioned how Berlant's take on the notion of crisis provides a useful lens for understanding present systemic instability. But the term crisis carries with it a long and intricate etymology, reflecting the shifting historical, experiential, and intellectual frameworks within which it has been understood. As Julia Kuznetski, Chiara Battisti, and Silvia Pellicer-Ortín write in their introduction to *The Routledge Companion to Literatures and Crisis*, crises "may resonate differently at different times and may only be grasped when viewed across the scales of both history and culture" (2). *Greenwood* resonates with Berlant's argument that "crisis is not exceptional to history or consciousness but a process embedded in the ordinary" (10). Accordingly, there is a critical continuum embedded in the narration that extends across the novel's structure and imbues its multitemporal plot. At the same time, the story advances in critical leaps, as it were, introducing successive ruptures that destabilize the reader's expectations. In fact, I argue that the story unfolds through the relentless production of crises, propelling the narrative while intensifying its sense of instability, and making of rupture the very mechanism of narrative rhythm. In this backward-forward process, the reader is repeatedly confronted with surprises, as relational patterns are constructed only to be disrupted, thus underscoring their fundamentally critical nature.

Let us jump, for instance, backward to the core tree ring to reach the abrupt origin of the Greenwood family in 1908 in a small town near Kingston, Ontario. It is then and there, we are told by an unnamed witness narrator, that two nine-year-old boys survive a train crash in the most unlikely way and become the protagonists of the most improbable story. The boys, who neither remember their names nor appear to be related, eventually settle in a small cabin on Mrs. Craig's property, where they develop a deep affinity for the surrounding woods (218). Soon after, they become "brothers" by decision of the townspeople, who arbitrarily pick their first names along with the surname Greenwood, an ironic gesture prompted by their early mistake of selling freshly cut wood without first allowing it to dry:

> [N]one of us had the heart to mention to the boys that they were supposed to first dry the green wood for a minimum of a year–and ideally, two or three [. . .].
>
> So this is how it came to be that instead of what we'd previously called them – either "those poor boys" or "those goddamned boys," depending on what they'd done that week – the pair came to be known as "the green wood boys."
>
> As years passed, the name settled upon them and rooted them in place. With it, they seemed less like ghosts or demons and more and more like regular boys. It became difficult for us to say whether they hadn't always carried the Greenwood name, even since before the train crash. (225–226)

Some reviewers have criticized the "flurry of happenstance" of Christie's plot, especially in the core rings of the two brothers (Saxby 21). Yet, while I agree that this part of the story is characterized by excess, I argue that it achieves a sense of exceptionality that sets the tone for the ensuing discussion of criticality throughout. In the first place, it undermines the genealogical project at the heart of the novel. In his Foucauldian study of the function of critical genealogy, Bernard Harcourt (170) argues that the objective of genealogical work must be to advance critical praxis, contributing and invigorating activity in valuable ways. Harcourt offers some examples of what this contribution may mean:

> Problematizing genealogy, for instance, emphasizes the importance of mental constructs that govern how we understand the world [. . .]. What problematization does is to show that something we take for granted,

> something that is common sense or received wisdom, something we have come to think of as inevitable, in fact, is something that has been constructed over time, often by happenstance, and that may lead us astray. (Harcourt 174)

In the context of the novel, the revelation that the Greenwood brothers are not blood related introduces a sense of arbitrariness in the family lineage that, the reader will gradually discover, will affect other characters as well. The new information about the origin of the family has a reshuffling effect of the type mentioned by Harcourt, transforming the meaning of previously settled events and thus forcing the reader to rethink the story of the Greenwoods. Narrated typically as an isolated dramatic event that disturbs the rhythm of everyday life in the small town, the train accident from which the two young strangers are literally ejected marks the beginning of the Greenwood family as it rewrites Christie's project as a critical genealogy. Moreover, identitary fakes go hand in hand with the destabilization of family origins. When Harris, having enlisted to fight in the First World War, begins to experience the first signs of visual impairment, Everett secretly resolves to protect him by assuming his brother's identity and enlisting in his place. In the second innermost ring of the story, which takes place in 1934, Harris, now completely blind, has become a successful timber tycoon, whereas Everett, returning from the war deeply damaged and afflicted by post-traumatic stress, hides as a squatter on a remote New Brunswick property, leading a precarious existence tapping maple trees. At this point, the reader is forced once more to reconfigure the family tree, coming to understand that Euphemia is Willow's mother and that Willow shares no blood relation with either Harris, who raises her, or Everett, who saves the baby from certain death. The plot constantly moves back and forth in this fashion, tracing a twisted path from the happenstance of the family origin to the relentless instability that structures 21st-century life in late capitalism.

There is yet another crucial way in which the innermost narrative ring becomes essential to the interpretation (and continuous reinterpretation) of the story. The unnamed narrator writes in the style of small-town chronicles of settler colonial life, with their naive tone and their emphasis on local anecdotes and gossip. In line with this genre, the narrator also speaks on behalf of the community, using a deliberately hyperbolic style to evoke the small-town atmosphere and make minor events seem momentous or even epic. Settler colonial studies have shown how certain minor genres, including local chronicles and letters, were part of a distinct settler discourse across the British Empire that opposed Indigenous resistance and challenged British humanitarian efforts to regulate colonial expansion (Lester; Storey). In Canada, early 20th-century chronicles of local life aimed at legitimizing and naturalizing the settler colonial project through the effacement of Indigenous presence and/or the omission of historical clash (Brydon 55). As Margery Fee convincingly argues, Canadian narratives of that period contributed meaningfully to the white settler's claim to the land by shaping competing notions of morally legitimate conduct in the colonies (1–16). Christie's narrator in the 1908 ring of the novel is firmly installed in this strategy of constructing what Dallas Jokic calls "settler whitespace," a colonial scheme that "is not just protective and expansive; it also tries to establish a primordial claim to the land" (15) by fabricating "a white nativity to territory" (16). But, as they explicitly allude to this strategy, the narrative simultaneously departs from genre expectations by exposing its underlying violence. The result is a crude account of early 20th-century small-town Canada, its picturesque portrait of life in the woods sharply undercut by dark passages that construct the settler colonial project in terms of a crisis of violence. Take, for instance, the following passage in which an unabashed narrator tells the story of how Mrs. and Mister Craig came all the way from Scotland to live in "the Land of the Trees":

> When the couple arrived in "the Land of the Trees," they found the thirty thickly wooded acres they'd petitioned from the Canadian Land Registry already occupied by a band of roving Mohawk, who'd been displaced from their traditional trapping grounds by a local lumber concern. Despite his compassionate ways, James Graig bought a rifle and raised a local militia to drive the band from his property, a brutal yet necessary act that many of us had once performed ourselves. Some of the Mohawk refused to vacate and grew so uppity there wasn't much to be done except shoot them as examples and burn their women and children. (219–220)

The reader is destabilized once more by the sudden discrepancy between the expectations of naiveté associated with these chronicles and the brutality of these words that attempt to justify the violent displacement of Indigenous peoples from their lands as routine and their murder as inevitable. Rather than directly confronting this history of violence and deprivation, Christie constructs the story *on* it, as it were, installing a critical undercurrent that, by linking settler colonialism and Canada's logging history, erodes the plot. Entangling colonial and environmental injuries in this way, this strategy is most explicit through Willow, who, trying to appease her colonial guilt, renounces all her privileges to live in her van with her son Liam and dedicates her life to counteract her father's extractivist logic: "The exploitation, the waste, the destruction of the land and its indigenous peoples were all laid bare, and worse, it was people like *her* who'd perpetrated these crimes" (92). But even the lumber tycoon Harris, for whom Canada is "the greatest storehouse of natural materials the world has ever known," wonders about the Indigenous right to the land he has stolen and its natural wood sold to foreign interests, experiencing moments of empathy with the trees that have made him rich: "And for a dizzy, drunken moment, Harris pities the trees. Especially for the trusting way they declare themselves to the world with their grand upward reach. At least gold and oil have the common sense to hide" (298). It could be argued that Christie presents extractive economy as a colonial residue, inviting the reader to reconsider and analyze this history and its effects on the lives of human and nonhuman beings. In that context, scholars of settler colonialism often foreground settler responsibility by exposing how there is a complicity between past injustices and present everyday attitudes that normalize or sustain the violence of Indigenous dispossession and marginalization (Palmer; MacDonald and Grafton). Yet the novel does not engage fully with these shocking discrepancies or explicitly condemn the violence intrinsic to the settler colonial project. It simply leaves those words there, reminding the reader that, as Dipesh Chakrabarty would put it, "the question of sovereignty of those who lost their lands and civilizations to European occupiers and invaders remains unanswered (and perhaps, disquietingly, unanswerable)" (10).

In her study of the representation of environmental catastrophes in recent postcolonial fiction, Justyna Poray-Wybranowska shows how a close reading of this literature may offer "a glimpse into how global historical phenomena impact individuals in a direct, tangible way," revealing "where and how larger historical threads become entangled with individual lives" (14). Close reading of that type shows "the ways colonial histories shape specific moments wherein subjects imbricated in these histories play out their relationships in ways that replicate, reinforce, or undermine them" (Poray-Wybranowska 14). In *Greenwood*, I have argued in this section, these complex relationships are articulated through critical ruptures that set the plot in motion, destabilizing the narrative by reconfiguring its elements once and again. The interrelated crises are represented as rooted in Canada's colonial history of dispossession and inseparable from its logics of extractivism, and the creation of Canada upon that history and that logic installs a continuous criticality that imbues generations and relations to the present settler colonial state. Simultaneously, however, the 21st-century narrative rings engage specifically with the crisis ordinariness of late capitalism, resonating with Berlant's description of systemic precarity in the present.

Crisis Ordinariness and Beyond

For Berlant, the ongoing process of life through attrition thwarts agentive power, leaving the subject drained of creative energy because "[t]he structural position of the overwhelmed life intensifies this foreshortening of consciousness and fantasy" (117). The Withering in the outermost ring is consistently described in those terms, not as a dramatic event but as a slow, prolonged, unsensational process leading to ecological exhaustion, affecting the economy at a global scale, and leaving subjects stranded in a physical and psychological state of apathy. Moreover, in the depiction of these quotidian struggles, Christie is invested in showing the differential structure of crises, with their generation of inequalities and their uneven allocation of social vulnerability.

The description of the visitors to Greenwood Arboreal Cathedral is particularly illustrative of this interest. They visit the island to forget the life they momentarily leave behind, structured by obscene class and economic asymmetries, as well as by environmental and health precarities. They are oblivious of the fact that the very Cathedral is run upon a system of racial capitalism, with its brown-skinned Indonesian chambermaids and Salvadoran groundskeepers (25). Having heard of the health benefits of *shinri-yoku*, the elite tourists want "to be healed," "to glean something rare and sustaining from its trees, to breathe their clean air and feel less hopeless among them" (7). Yet, even as their economic privilege affords a measure of protection, they remain haunted by the very structures of inequality that sustain it:

> On the Mainland, the Pilgrims live in opulent, climate-controlled towers that protect them from rib retch–the new strain of tuberculosis endemic to the world's dust-choked slums, named after the cough that snaps ribs like kindling, especially children–yet they still arrive at the Cathedral seeking something ineffable that's missing from their lives. (7)

The island figures here as a "happy object," the site for the expectation of "good feelings" (Ahmed 21). But, endowed with the fetishistic character of modern travel, its function as a source of pleasure remains paradoxically bound to a feeling of mourning (Braun 109–155).

Butler praises Berlant's work for its intricate exploration of "how economic contradictions suffuse emotional life, ways of hoping and losing, but they also show how strong emotional investments keep such systems in place." This holds as much for the pilgrim's cruel expectations as for Jake's evident lack of them. A climate refugee, Jake is forced to take a job "in a silly theme park at the edge of the world" (33). She is highly overqualified for it, but she needs to pay off her student debt, which, she is shocked to find out, did survive the Withering (24). Subjected to alcoholism and the consequent daily hang-overs, she is aware that her "flat and uninspiring" speeches to the island visitors will result in bad reviews that may make her lose her job (459). Her life is thus narrated as a monotonous struggle to simply survive, devoid of hope, let alone dreams, echoing Berlant's question: "Is 'having a life' now the process to which one gets resigned, after dreaming of the good life, or not even dreaming?" (117).

But, if there is a story that captures the relentless weariness of the present, that is Liam Greenwood's in the 2008 ring, which speaks directly to "the way the attrition of the subject of capital articulates survival with slow death" (Berlant 117). Liam is Willow's son and Jake's father, although they have never met. After a traumatic childhood due to his mother's insensitive carelessness, together with her radical antimaterialism and nomadic ways, he is stuck in a life pattern that only intensifies his sense of deprivation, precarity and vulnerability. Having been evicted from his house, he lives in his van while working illegally fixing expensive houses for wealthy people in the United States. He has become a carpenter of "reclaimed wood," the new buzzword designed to appease his customers' guilt over extractive economies while promising them a semblance of authenticity: "Who knew that the Olympian-rich crave the A-word as desperately as they do" Liam wonders (53). The narrative reproduces Liam's train of thought as he wakes up on the floor of one of those houses that he is renovating and discovers that he cannot move his legs: "An unconsciousness. For what duration he doesn't know. Also, his legs are oddly numb and feel as heavy as sandbags. [. . .] *This is not my house*, he thinks. It's a rich person's house. A weekend house. Used only a few weeks a year" (45). Liam's physical immobility serves as a powerful trope for his precarious existence, working with no visa and no contractor's insurance: "it was pricey," and, anyway, "his clients are happy to pay cash" (426). Moreover, his injured body is the material vehicle to narrate his existential stasis: "There are states he's always feared more profoundly than death: abandonment, helplessness, dependence on others. But it's uselessness that terrifies him most of all" (427). The use of the present tense intensifies the sense of agonic relentlessness, dragging the reader to partake as witness of Liam's slow death.

This narrative ring is thus marked by the suspension of time and the elusiveness of agency, illustrating the paralyzing effects of crisis ordinariness in both material and metaphorical senses. At the same time, however, Christie pushes beyond this contemporary plight to explore the reparative possibilities opened up by memory and language. Both of these competing impulses coexist within the

narrative, generating a productive tension. On the one hand, there are moments that clearly resonate with Berlant's predicament that certain artworks do not seek repair, but rather stray "beneath the radar where things go without saying not because they are censored or normative, but because, as the body politic wanders around stunned in the crisis ordinary, it is not clear what to say" (Berlant 249). Subject to the apathy of confusion, Liam, who "has never cared about politics. Or art. Or immaterial thought" (58), and whose endless workdays leave "little opportunity for his memories to intrude upon him, which is just how he prefers it" (53), now lies on the floor unable to move his legs: "the years of toil, labor, and hard living are finally settling upon him. He's never been so exhausted in his life" (57). On the other, there is a growing effort to confront the uncertainty of suspension and to make sense of his life story, which aligns Christie with Berlant's call to reimagine life's unrewarding tediousness (250). As he slowly comes to understand that he has suffered a fatal accident that will confine him to a wheelchair for the rest of his life, memory begins to resurface: "A flock of details rushes in with the pain, like birds returning to roost in his mind's branches. His name is Liam. He's Canadian [. . .] He's thirty-four years old and despite his mother's best efforts, he's still a Greenwood" (46). What follows is a narrative saturated with regret, where Liam's need to articulate the guilt of having abandoned his daughter Jake converges with a tentative belief in the healing possibilities of letting his memories flow:

> All the years he squandered, high as a satellite in Oxy-Cotin; all the parts of his story he's left out, all the things he refuses to think about. But while he'll never be able to atone for all his mistakes, there might still be a few left for him to repair. And there might still be parts of the story left for him to tell. *So let the memories come*, he thinks. *What does it matter now?* (428)

As Hanna Antonia Schaefer puts it in her study of Berlant's thought, the impasse could be seen as the site for "an understanding of agency and subjectivity in relation to moments or periods of drift, irresolution and hesitancy, but also of attentiveness and experimentation" (58). Liam's story unfolds as a scene of creative impasse, where the character's increasingly delirious mind surrenders to the imperative to remember and tell, and this surrender brings a measure of relief. More broadly, this articulates the novel's engagement with crisis through the therapeutic potential of storytelling, a potential that is also crucial to the sustained and vital interconnection between humans and trees.

Vibrant Relations

In her study of the vibrant materiality of the world at large, Bennett puts forward the need "to begin to experience the relationship between persons and other materialities more horizontally, is to take a step toward a more ecological sensibility" (Bennett 10). Bennett describes this experience in terms of an epiphany:

> Vital materialists will thus try to linger in those moments during which they find themselves fascinated by objects, taking them as clues to the material vitality that they share with them. This sense of a strange and incomplete commonality with the out-side may induce vital materialists to treat nonhumans—animals, plants, earth, even artifacts and commodities—more carefully, more strategically, more ecologically. (Bennett 17–18)

Greenwood is clearly devoted to the examination of these material and philosophical issues, especially in its approach to the relationship between humans and trees. All the Greenwoods, regardless of their different views of nature, relate to the trees in embodied, affective, reverential, and often contradictory ways that resonate with Bennett's words. Despite a whole life of cutting trees down, Harris is extremely sensitive to the magnificence of trees, "and even after all these years forests remain the landscape of his most inner self" (140). Losing his eyesight at an early age introduces an important degree of vulnerability in his impenetrable character, opening a sensory archive that diverts the narrative from the linear account of his economic success. Later, he falls in love with a man who reads poetry to him in an Irish accent, and this again transforms his affects toward the trees: "With Feeney now at his side, Harris is newly alert to the brutality of logging and the general frailty of life" (273). He shares with Everett, whose body is described as "a crooked old oak" (431), a preference of trees over people (106). Willow reveres the trees to such an extent that

she dedicates her life to protecting them, even at the expense of fulfilling her responsibilities toward her own son Liam. While attending the funeral of her father, she looks at an old photograph of him proudly standing before a hip of giant cut logs and wonders "how he could have encountered beings of such unimpeachable grace and beauty and felt the urge (not to mention *the right!*) to destroy them" (404). Her son Liam opposes his mother's obsessive love for trees, although, skeptical of his own marketing strategy and aware that his primary material is ultimately "reclaimed" from nature, he treats wood with immense care and respect, wondering if the trees have souls, "which makes wood a kind of flesh" (69). Similarly, Jake dedicates her life to studying trees, and, confronted with crucial life decisions, she follows her grandmother Willow by choosing the trees over the demands of motherhood or marriage. At the same time, she is fully aware of the "*unspeakable irony*" (14) of her job, and that, as her veteran fellow coworker Knut puts it, "there is something truly repellent about the notion of reducing what is the very pinnacle of natural magnificence to merely a therapeutic backdrop for the wealthy" (13). These contradictions animate the Greenwood lives by underscoring, to use Bennett's words, a *strange and incomplete commonality* with the lives of the trees.

Additionally, deeply enmeshed in the novel's complex web of relations and showing the tremendous vitality intrinsic to their materiality, the trees themselves appear endowed with "an active, earthy, not-quite-human capaciousness" (Bennett 3). I have already examined the book's original tree-trunk concentric structure and how the arboreal trope activates the plot. In that regard, the novel subscribes to a distributive form of agency that decenters the subject by transferring the root of action to "a swarm of vitalities at play" (Bennett 31–32). The text presents multiple configurations that further foreground the deep entanglement of human and arboreal lives. In addition to the central trope of the family name, Willow is named after the willow tree outside Temple's farm, the only landmark that survives the Great Dust Bowl in the 1930s: "The big weeping willow near the porch, the one that's like a great, green room when you go inside it" (433). Liam dresses up like a Douglas fir, "wrapping himself in gray cardboard bark and branches, adorning himself with pinecones carved from her wine corks" to attract his mother's attention (52). Everett dreams of trees "mostly": "Trees I once knew. Trees I don't know yet. Sometimes they're aiding me, and sometimes they're falling on me. Sometimes I'm planting them, and sometimes I'm cutting them down. [. . .] I think if you ever cut my head open, it'd be one big root ball in there, all tangled and grown together" (303). Various passages in the novel also echo forestry scientist and conservationist Suzanne Simard's description of the trees in a forest as a "web of interdependence, linked by a system of underground channels, where they perceive and connect and relate with an ancient intricacy and wisdom that can no longer be denied" (4). Regardless of their differences, all the Greenwoods share the idea that even cut wood is a living thing, "moving moisture through its capillaries. Breathing and twisting, expanding and contracting. Like a body" (325).

To some extent, then, Christie's attention to the vibrancy of trees seems in line with recent calls to put "the geological time and the biological time of evolution in conversation with the time of human history and experience" (Chakrabarty 7). Humans are frequently described through arboreal metaphors, while trees are conversely endowed with human attributes. However, the novel also suggests that, however imaginative its reach, fiction remains necessarily constrained by anthropocentrism. While the attempt at reciprocity may betray an awareness of the need to push the conceptual boundaries of anthropomorphism, the text mostly speaks of its inevitability. Knut's own critique in his goodbye note to Jake proclaims this paradox:

> *They stand. They reach. They climb. They thirst. They drop their leaves. They fall. You see, Jake? We make them human. With our verbs. But really, we shouldn't. Because they're our betters. Our kings and queens. (We gave them crowns, didn't we?) And they are the closest things we have to gods.* (467)

These contradictory analogies ultimately expose the impossibility of resisting anthropomorphism, of imagining "with our verbs" without simultaneously reinscribing the very conceptual hierarchies that undergird them. In this context, Bennett argues that

> Attentiveness to matter and its powers will not solve the problem of human exploitation or oppression, but it can inspire a greater sense of the extent to which all bodies are kin in the sense of inextricably enmeshed in a dense network of relations. And in a knotted world of vibrant matter, to harm one section of the web may very well be to harm oneself. Such an enlightened or expanded notion of self-interest is good for humans. (Bennett 13)

Greenwood joins Bennett's project in underscoring the material and affective dimensions of the relations between trees and humans. Besides, even while fully accepting an anthropocentric frame, Christie enriches the novel's *knotted world* with a further layer of vibrancy, the one that circulates between trees and books: "How intimately a book is related to the tree and its rings, [Jake] thinks. The layers of time, preserved, for all to examine" (41). As I move toward my conclusion, I wish to return to that vibrant relation that runs like a chorus throughout the story and is often the source of its most extraordinary events.

Coda: Crisis Extraordinariness

Berlant ends her study of the attrition effect of everyday cruelties by alluding to the power of fantasy and the imagination to combat the exhaustion of the present (263). For them, writing and artistic practices often reveal a necessary utopian impulse. And, in that respect, although concerning the political and social instability of a particular time and place, their study of criticality transcends that original framework. As I have argued, *Greenwood* takes up this thread and approaches the notion of crisis from different angles and across diverse temporalities, exploring its relational, materialist, and affective dimensions and how agency is prevented and/or rearticulated in the midst of overlapping contingencies. The large time span allows Christie to weave these complex issues into an intricate web of interconnections that often oscillates between rupture and ordinariness, approaching life as an ongoing negotiation with precarity rather than its resolution. At the same time, as I have shown, there is a parallel interest in showing how critical impasses can also function as a site of possibility for imagining otherwise. The novel's narrative layers are bound together through a series of interconnected crises that precipitate extraordinary events: from the survival of two boys thrown from a moving train, to the discovery of a baby miraculously alive and suspended from a tree in a winter forest, to the seemingly impossible endurance of the Greenwood Island trees themselves. The articulation of an intimate relation between human and nonhuman actors further generates a sense of awe. Moreover, Christie explicitly foregrounds the transformative potential of literature to engage criticality and recast it as a site of potential. In this regard, the novel is nothing short of extraordinary.

The text is filled with scenes involving discussions of books, or characters writing, reading, and reciting, each rendered with extraordinary poetic beauty, as in Temple's description of the sound her books made as a cyclone destroyed her library: "She'll grapple with how one could possibly capture precisely the sound of ten thousand books drawn up into the air and scattered for hundred of miles [. . .] they sounded like birds" (394). Poetic objects significantly endure beyond the Greenwoods' many predicaments. Harris's blindness opens the sound archive of his lover Feeney's readings of poetry, which Feeney records and sends to him long after their breakup. These records are then passed on from Harris, who listens daily to the sound of his lover's voice, to Willow, who finds them calming when she is dying of cancer. Willow then plays them for Liam when he is struggling with his drug addiction, "the lilting rhythms of the man's voice sooth[ing] his shredded nerves" (60). The records end up in a cardboard box that Jake inherits from her father and that will be confiscated by Holtcorp at the end of the novel, potentially marking the beginning of a new life in the possession of other listeners.

But, if there is one poetic object that competes with the trees in underlying the novel's structure and supporting its web of interconnections, that is the journal, which is found with the baby (Willow) hanging from a tree. Despite his illiteracy, Everett has an intuitive understanding of its personal value and is determined to protect it. Before he hides it in Temple's library, he writes on its cover the "crudely penciled words, scrawled in a child's block print: "proportee of willo greenwud" (41). The journal is lost in the Great Bowl and then found by a farmer years later.

And, even though some characters lose their lives over it, the reader has no access to its contents, except for its last entry at the end of the novel, when the journal falls unexpectedly in Jake's hands: "*Though it embarrasses me to say it,*" writes Euphemia in her antiquated cursive script, *"I want to be a writer like Virginia Woolf. What would that sort of rapture feel like? To have words overtake you? [. . .] For so long I've felt as though my life were a seed that the soil of the world refuses. [. . .] Everything is fraying & falling apart"* (499). These last words bring the novel's temporal, geographical, and genealogical layers into a shared frame, from the early 20th century to 2038, from New Brunswick to the West Coast, from Euphemia to Jake, recasting the notion of crisis through an affective lens and tracing a continuity in how subjects inhabit and respond to their worlds. Euphemia's journal also amplifies the novel's vibrant entanglement between stories and trees in a very material way, since, as Archer points out, "[t]he paper she writes on has, in effect, a second life, or a continuation of life of the tree from which it was made" (142). Moreover, the survival of this fragile object across the different temporalities and amid the various crises explored in the text constitutes an extraordinary event in itself, linking the narrative threads and imbuing the intergenerational story with both purpose and meaning.

In their editorial to a special issue of *Canada and Beyond* on ecology and affect in literature, Stephanie Oliver and Kit Dobson ask: "What are the literary affects of this moment of ecological crisis? What models do writers offer to us for thinking through this time? (11) Striking a similar chord, in their issue of *Canadian Literature* on poetics and extraction, Max Karpinski and Melanie Dennis Unrau wonder, "in what ways might cultural production and scholarship in the field of 'Canadian literature' address the unfolding, intensifying, and deeply entangled environmental and social crises that mark the present moment?" (1). Christie's novel takes up these questions and expands them to explore the complex ways in which narrative can effectively remain, to use Butler's words, *a hopeful site of experimentation* and *a source of promise*. The novel shows how, as DeLoughrey puts it, "the Anthropocene is *material* in that it concerns what can be measured and experienced, and it is *representational* in that it raises vital questions as to how the planet as a system can be signified" (DeLoughrey 3). This affirms the role of narrative, literature, and the arts as critical within this framework, for what is thought of as "critical" is, by definition, necessary, urgent, and crucial.

Notes

1. A discussion of the specific elements of arboreal fiction is beyond the scope of this paper. See Schoene for an analysis of the role of "arborealist novels" in the current shift in interest toward more-than-human econarratives. Schoene also offers a detailed reading of *Barkskins* and *The Overstory* in that context.
2. For a critical approach to settler colonialism as an interpretive paradigm in the context of Canada, see Palmer. Carey and Silverstein, in their turn, place the origins of the field in Indigenous activism and scholarship, which they consider crucial for the development of the field.

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